

The Exorcism of Emily Rose

Extreme Ultra-Density Draft: Chapters 9 & 10

CHAPTER 9: FIRST NIGHT

November 1976.

The first time it fully took her, it wasn't a monster. It wasn't a voice. It was a smell.

Emily was asleep in her dorm room. It was a Friday night. Alice had gone home to Chicago for the weekend to see a boyfriend she claimed was "in a band" but was probably just unemployed.

The dorm was quiet. A rare, heavy silence that settled over the cinderblock walls like a blanket.

Emily was dreaming.

In the dream, she was back on the farm. But the corn was dead. Black stalks rattling in a wind that smelled of sulfur. The sky was the color of a bruise.

She was walking toward the barn. She didn't want to go, but her legs moved on their own. *Left. Right. Left. Right.*

The barn door was open. A mouth in the darkness.

And inside...

Something was waiting.

She woke up choking.

Her eyes snapped open.

The room was dark, lit only by the amber streetlights filtering through the cheap blinds.

She coughed, her lungs seizing.

The air in the room was thick. Oily.

"Fire," she thought. Panic flared in her chest, hot and sharp.

She sat up, throwing the covers off.

But there was no orange glow. No smoke alarm screaming. No sound of crackling wood.

Just the smell.

It was overpowering.

Burning hair. Burning rubber.

And underneath that... meat.

Seared meat.

Like a steak left on a grill until it turned to charcoal.

Emily gagged, covering her mouth with her hand.

She swung her legs out of bed.

The floor was cold. Freezing.

She walked to the window. Maybe there was a fire outside. Maybe the dumpster was burning.

She pulled the blinds up.

Nothing. Just the empty courtyard. The fog.

The smell was coming from *inside* the room.

Then the weight hit her.

It wasn't a gradual pressure. It was instant.

It felt as if the gravity in the room had suddenly increased tenfold.

CRACK.

Emily fell to her knees.

The pain was blinding. Her kneecaps slammed into the hardwood floor with the force of a hammer strike. She felt the cartilage compress, the bone grind against the wood.

She tried to stand.

She couldn't.

Her legs were locked.

Not cramped. Locked. Rigid as iron bars.

She tried to crawl.

Her arms wouldn't move. Her elbows were pinned to her sides by invisible bands of steel.

She was paralyzed.

Trapped in her own body.

"Help," she whispered.

But her voice was gone. Her throat was clamped shut. Her tongue felt swollen, heavy, like a slug in her mouth.

She stared at the floor. The grain of the wood. The dust bunnies under Alice's bed.

She could see her own breath puffing out in white clouds on the floorboards.

It's freezing.

Why was it freezing? The radiator was hissing in the corner.

She tried to lift her head.

It took every ounce of strength she had. Her neck muscles screamed.

She looked at the clock on her desk.

The red numbers burned in the dark.

3:00 AM.

The colon didn't blink.

Time had stopped.

Then, she heard it.

Creak.

The door to her closet.

She had closed it before bed. She always closed it. She hated the look of empty clothes hanging in the dark. Like shed skins.

The door was opening.

Slowly.

Inch by inch.

Eeeeeeeee.

The hinges shrieked in the silence.

Emily watched, her heart hammering against her ribs like a fist. *Thump-thump-thump.*

The door swung wide.

It was dark inside. Darker than the room.

But something was moving in the clothes.

Shifting.

Rustling.

Like a large animal settling into a nest.

A coat fell off a hanger. *Slump.*

Then a sweater.

And then... a face appeared in the darkness.

It wasn't a face.

It was a mask of melting wax.

The features were sliding off the skull. One eye was lower than the other. The mouth was a vertical slash.

It smiled.

A wet, glistening smile that revealed too many teeth.

Emily tried to scream.

Help me. Jesus, help me.

But her mouth wouldn't open. Her jaw was locked tight.

The thing in the closet stepped out.

It was tall. Seven feet. Thin as a rail. Its skin was grey, translucent, like parchment stretched over bone.

It walked toward her.

It didn't have feet. It floated an inch above the floor.

It stopped in front of her.

It leaned down.

It smelled of the grave. Of old earth and rotting flowers.

It whispered in her ear.

"Emily..."

The voice didn't come from the thing's mouth. It came from inside her own head.

It sounded like her father. But wrong. Twisted.

"Emily... why did you leave us?"

The pressure increased. She was being crushed. Her ribs groaned. She felt a rib crack. A sharp, hot needle of pain in her side.

"You think you can hide here? In the city? With your books?"

The thing reached out a hand. Its fingers were long, tipped with black claws.

It touched her cheek.

Its skin was burning hot.

Where it touched, her skin blistered.

"You are ours," the voice whispered. *"'You have always been ours.'"

Emily closed her eyes.

She focused on the pain in her knees. The pain was real. The pain was an anchor.

Hail Mary, full of grace...

She prayed in her mind. Screaming the words silently.

...the Lord is with thee...

The thing laughed. A sound like tearing metal.

"She can't hear you. She is in Heaven. You are in the pit."

Blessed art thou among women...

The weight grew heavier. It felt like the ceiling was coming down on her.

...and blessed is the fruit of thy womb, Jesus.

At the name of Jesus, the thing shrieked.

It recoiled.

The pressure vanished.

Instantly.

Emily collapsed forward, her face hitting the floor.

She gasped, sucking in air.

The smell was gone.

The cold was gone.

She looked up.

The closet door was closed.

The room was empty.

She looked at the clock.

3:01.

The numbers blinked.

Emily lay on the floor, shivering. Her knees throbbed. Her cheek burned where the thing had touched her.

She reached up and touched her face.

Her fingers came away wet.

Blood.

And something else.

Soot.

She curled into a ball on the floor and wept.

But she didn't call for help.

Because she knew.

No one could help her.

The war had begun. And she was the battlefield.

CHAPTER 10: ERIN INVESTIGATES

The Rose farm was a grey smudge on the horizon of the flat Midwest landscape.

Erin Bruner drove her rental car down the long dirt road. The suspension groaned with every pothole.

It was raining. Of course. A relentless, cold drizzle that turned the world into a watercolor painting left out in the storm.

The fields were dead. Brown stalks of corn, broken and rotting in the mud.

Erin gripped the wheel.

She felt... exposed here.

In the city, she was insulated by glass and steel. Here, there was nothing between her and the sky. Nothing between her and the horizon.

It felt like being on the surface of the moon.

She parked in front of the farmhouse.

It was a white clapboard house, two stories, with a wraparound porch that leaned dangerously to the left. The paint was peeling in long strips, revealing the grey wood underneath.

It looked like a house that was slowly dying.

Erin got out of the car. She pulled her trench coat tight.

The wind bit at her face. It smelled of wet earth and manure.

She walked to the porch. The stairs creaked. *Groan.*

She knocked on the door.

It opened immediately.

Maria Rose stood there.

Emily's mother was a small woman, worn down by grief like a stone in a river. Her hair was grey, pulled back in a severe bun. Her hands were red, rough from work.

But her eyes were clear. Blue. Piercing.

"Ms. Bruner," she said. Her voice was soft, but it carried. "Father Moore said you would come."

The kitchen was warm. It smelled of yeast and coffee. A wood stove crackled in the corner.

"Coffee?" Maria asked.

"Please."

Erin sat at the table. It was a heavy oak table, the surface scratched and scarred by decades of meals.

She opened her briefcase. She took out a notepad.

"Mrs. Rose, I need to ask you some questions. About Emily's childhood."

Maria poured the coffee into a chipped mug. Her hand was steady.

"Emily was happy," she said, sitting down opposite Erin. "She was full of light. She loved this farm. She loved God."

"Was there any history of mental illness? In the family? Depression? Mood swings?"

Maria shook her head. "No. We are healthy people. Hardworking."

"Mrs. Rose... the medical report says Emily had Temporal Lobe Epilepsy. It causes hallucinations. Hearing voices. Seeing things."

Maria looked at Erin. Her gaze was pitying.

"You think it was a sickness."

"I think it's a medical explanation. And it's the explanation the prosecution is going to use."

"Can medicine make a girl speak in languages she never learned?" Maria asked quietly. "Can medicine make a girl know things she couldn't know?"

"What things?"

"She knew about my sin," Maria whispered. She looked down at her hands. "I had a baby. Before I met Nathaniel. I gave it up. No one knew. Not even my husband."

Erin paused. Her pen hovered over the page.

"She looked at me... with those black eyes... and she told me. She told me the name I had given the baby in my heart. *Sarah.*"

"Suggestion," Erin said, her voice professional. "Cold reading. Psychics do it all the time. They pick up on cues."

"It wasn't a trick, Ms. Bruner. It was... knowledge. Dark knowledge."

Maria stood up.

"Come with me. I want to show you something."

She put on a heavy wool shawl. She opened the back door.

"Where are we going?"

"The barn."

The walk to the barn was short, but it felt like miles. The wind pushed against them. The mud sucked at Erin's expensive boots.

The barn loomed ahead. Dark. Silent.

Maria pushed the door open.

It was cold inside. Colder than the outside.

The air was still. Stagnant.

"This is where she died," Maria said.

Erin looked around.

It was a typical barn. High rafters. Bales of hay. Tools hanging on the walls.

But in the center of the threshing floor...

A military cot.

It was stained. Dark patches on the canvas.

And on the floor...

Erin walked closer.

Scratches.

Deep gouges in the hard oak planks.

Dozens of them.

They looked like they had been made by a wild animal. A bear. Or a wolf.

Erin knelt down. She touched the wood. The splinters were sharp.

"Did an animal do this?"

"Emily did this," Maria said. Her voice echoed in the vast space. "With her fingernails."

"Why?"

"To keep from floating away."

Erin looked up. "Floating?"

"Levitating, Ms. Bruner. They lifted her up. Like a doll. She dug into the floor to hold on."

Erin touched the scratches again.

She felt it then.

The static.

The same feeling she had in her apartment at 3:00 AM.

The hair on her arms stood up.

She smelled it.

Copper.

Sulfur.

Rotting lilies.

She looked at the corner of the barn. The shadows seemed to be moving. Coalescing. Thickening into a shape.

A tall, thin shape.

"We should go," Erin said, standing up quickly. Her heart was racing.

"You feel it, don't you?" Maria asked.

"I feel the cold."

"You feel *them*," Maria said. "They are still here. They are waiting for the trial. They are waiting for *you*."

Erin walked out of the barn. Fast.

She didn't run, but it was close.

She got in her car. She locked the doors.

She started the engine.

She drove down the driveway, dust billowing behind her.

She didn't look back.

But she checked the rearview mirror.

And for a second... just a second...

She saw a face in the back seat.

Smiling.

She blinked.

It was gone.

Just the empty leather seats.

Erin gripped the wheel. Her knuckles were white.

"Psychosis," she whispered. "It's contagious. It's suggestibility."

But she knew.

She knew the smell.

She knew the feeling of eyes on her neck.

She drove faster.

Trying to outrun the sunset.

Trying to outrun the dark.